

DEEP DIVE — THE PRODUCER'S MASTER STRATEGY

*The whole producing craft, applied to this film. For Tomislav Kovačić, director & producer.
Compiled 14 July 2026.*

Built from nine verified research passes + the project's own documents. Companion files in this folder:

MASTER-PLAN.md (dated operating plan) • RESEARCH-CRAFT.md • RESEARCH-MONEY.md •
RESEARCH-LEGAL-DELIVERY.md • COPRODUCER-SHORTLIST.md • US-FUNDS.md • RELEASES-DRAFT.md •
IDFA-FORUM-ENTRY-DRAFT.md

How to use this: read Part I–II once, tonight. Part III–V are the reference you return to before every money conversation, every contract, every festival decision. Part VI is the calendar you live by.

PART I — THE JOB

1 • What a producer actually is

The director asks "what is the film?" The producer asks "how does the film get to exist, get finished, get seen, and not destroy us on the way?" Concretely, the producer owns:

1. **The money** — raising it, planning its arrival (cash flow), spending it against a budget, reporting it.
2. **The paper** — every right the film needs, acquired in writing, filed, provable (chain of title).
3. **The people** — hiring the team, in the right order, on signed deal memos.
4. **The schedule** — shoots, edit, finishing, festival clock, delivery dates; and the discipline when they collide.
5. **The risk** — insurance, legal review, safety, contingency; seeing the trap two moves before it springs.
6. **The relationships** — funders, broadcasters, co-producers, sales agent, festivals. The producer is who they call.
7. **The delivery** — the brutal technical/legal package that converts a finished film into paid money.

The director's currency is trust with the subjects and the truth of the cut. The producer's currency is **credibility with money** — budgets that add up, promises that get kept, paper that exists.

2 • Your dual-hat problem — named honestly

You are currently director + producer + DP + editor-adjacent + app developer + **sole financier**. This is how great first films get started and how they die at rough cut. What predictably fails when one person holds all hats:

- **Financing stalls during shoots** (you can't chase HAVC paperwork from a boat off Lastovo) — and shoots stall during financing.

- **The paper doesn't get done** — releases, deal memos, licenses feel skippable at midnight after a dive day. They are the sale.
- **Nobody negotiates for you** — when you're the director asking the four for life-story rights, you're also the friend; a producer can be the "bad cop" the friendship needs.
- **No one checks your budget's honesty** — solo producers under-budget post by half, always, because the shoot is vivid and the M&E track is not.
- **Burnout** — the only non-renewable resource on this production is you.
- **On-set collapse** — film-school truth (The Independent Film School): try to produce and direct on the same set and you end up producing, with no director on set. Add DP duties in safety-critical freediving conditions and divided attention stops being an inefficiency and becomes a hazard.

One structural advantage you already have: your two camera operators double as post people — that's the **assistant-editor function** (the ADE says the AE should start months *before* the editor, organizing, grouping, syncing transcripts — "proper organization is one of the single most important factors in how quickly an editor can work"). Formalize it: from Lastovo onward they log, transcribe, and string out after every block. That's edit prep, not admin.

The delegation ladder — what you hand off, in order, as money arrives:

1. **Production management / logistics** (first euro of external money): a production manager or line-producer-days for Lastovo/USA — travel, permits, insurance, call sheets, payments. Cheapest hire, biggest hour-return.
2. **Finance & admin > the Croatian co-producer** (before the 10 Sept HAVC rok): HAVC/Eurimages administration, cost reports, audits, contracts. This is what the co-producer attach IS (> COPRODUCER-SHORTLIST.md; Restart first call).
3. **The edit > a real editor** (by assembly, Nov–Dec 2026): the doc editor is the film's second author. You cannot be your own editor on an ensemble feature and keep judgment — you've seen every frame get made.
4. **Sales & festival strategy > sales agent** (from rough cut): their relationships are the product.

What you never delegate: the relationship with the four, the 2023 chapter's handling, final creative word, and signature authority on the company.

3 • Your position on the board (assets & constraints)

Assets: total access + trust of the four (locked by no one else) · 2 of ~7 blocks shot, including an erupting Etna and an unreported world-record blackout with a post-event interview · a provable injustice (negative WADA-lab tests, ITA no-violation, ethics-only ruling, peer-reviewed rebuttal — Škerbić et al. 2025) · a subject inducted into a Vegas hall of fame in the same class as Garry Kasparov (26 Sept, Palms) · zero equity sold · a working production OS (this app). **Constraints:** new company (zero track record — HAVC scores the producer's last 3 films) · €10–25k personal bridge · one person, five jobs · no releases signed yet (fix at Lastovo) · deadline stack: **IDFA Forum 25 July • Lastovo 20 July • HAVC 10 September.**

PART II — THE MAP

4 • The eight stages, and where you stand

Stage	What it is	Deep Dive status
1. Development	Story, access, treatment, deck, sizzle; typically 3–12 months	(done) Effectively done (bible, interview architecture, 2 blocks shot). Sizzle = last dev asset, due THIS WEEK
2. Financing	The plan, applications, co-producers, markets; 6–18 months, overlaps everything	(pending) NOW › mid-2027. IDFA Forum › HAVC › partners › Eurimages
3. Pre-production	Per-shoot: permits, insurance, crew, releases, logistics	Rolling per block (Lastovo now; USA in Aug)
4. Production	The shoots	(pending) Jul–Nov 2026: Lastovo (20 Jul–9 Aug) › USA (~3 wks around 26 Sep) › Cyprus variant (27 Sep–10 Oct, the four decide) › Rijeka lab (Nov) › coda
5. Post	Assembly › rough › fine › lock › finishing; 9–14 months for a film like this	Nov 2026 › summer 2027 (see §14)
6. Festival & sales	Premiere strategy, agent, markets	Rough cut spring 2027 › Cannes Docs May › premiere autumn 2027
7. Distribution	The deals: streamer/broadcasters/theatrical/tours	Late 2027 › 2028
8. Delivery & afterlife	The technical/legal package; impact, tours, home release	Q4 2027 › 2028. Budgeted from today, not discovered at the end

5 • The realistic calendar (the one honest version)

- **Jul 2026:** sizzle · IDFA Forum entry (25th) · d.o.o. + Očevidnik · releases drafted · Lastovo shoot begins (20th) · lawyer engaged.
- **Aug 2026:** Lastovo (deep 2023 sit, releases signed, family archive, Cyprus decision) · HAVC application built with co-producer · sponsor wave 1 · USA prep (ESTA/insurance/permits/ISHOF/Kasparov release).
- **Sep–Oct 2026:** HAVC in (10th) · USA tour (Vegas 26th) · Cyprus variant · CPH:FORUM submission (early Nov deadline).
- **Nov–Dec 2026:** IDFA + Forum (15–18 Nov) — meet agents (MetFilm first), broadcasters, co-producers · Rijeka lab shoot · rebate application before that block · Whickers submission (~Nov, if budget-cap pre-check clears) · HRT doc editorial meeting · editor hired · **assembly begins.**
- **Q1 2027:** edit · HAVC decision lands (~Dec/Jan) · Eurimages application (first 2027 deadline) once IT/HU partner signed · WEMW/EDP/ZagrebDox Pro markets · coda shoot if not done.
- **Q2 2027:** rough cut › feedback screenings › sales agent formally attached › **Cannes Docs market screening (May)** › fine cut · edit lab if selected.

- **Q3 2027:** picture lock (Jun–Jul) › legal read BEFORE lock › finishing: conform, grade, sound design, mix + **filled M&E**, titles, masters · E&O bound · **world premiere: Telluride (early Sep) or TIFF Docs** · European premiere held for IDFA Nov 2027.
- **Q4 2027 › Q1 2028:** the sale (weeks-to-months post-premiere is normal) · delivery (budget 2–4 months for it) · Croatian theatrical event release · Banff/Kendal/ocean tours · series version cut for TV/streaming afterlife.

The rule that governs the calendar: the edit is where the film is made — never steal months from post to hit an earlier festival. Sundance 2027 is already correctly dead for this reason; if lock slips, the premiere moves to CPH:DOX/Tribeca 2028, not the mix to half its days.

The honest total: 58% of documentary makers report 1–5 years for the whole project (CMSI/IDA field study); a vérité feature realistically runs ~**3 years from committed development to release** — for us that's mid-2026 › 2028 including the sale and delivery. Budget your life, savings, and the studio's other work for that number, not for the shoot dates. And the ADE's warning stands behind every schedule decision: squeezed edit schedules end up driving total costs *higher*, not lower.

PART III — THE MONEY (full detail in RESEARCH-MONEY.md)

6 • Budget anatomy — what €1.2M actually contains

Memorize the shape, not the lines: **production ~ 30% • everything after the shoot ~ 30% • "invisible" money ~ 25%** (your fees 10%, company fee 7% — HAVC caps it there, verified NN 144/2014 — insurance/legal/E&O 3%, publicity 4%) · **contingency ~ 9–10%** (0% contingency reads amateur, not efficient). Editing alone: ~1 month per 10 finished minutes (~9 months for 90'), doubled tendencies for vérité. Delivery package €25–60k. E&O €10–20k for our risk profile. Archival at commercial rates ~ \$50–80/second — get 2023-footage quotes NOW, in development, not in the online.

The two-budget strategy (be honest about scale): real HAVC doc grants run €40–90k per film; Croatian creative docs commonly finish at €300–600k. Your €1.2–1.5M is IDFA-Forum-upper-cluster scale and only closes with the full international stack. So build both: **Budget A "the core film" ~€700–800k** — closable with HAVC + HRT + one minority partner + Eurimages + rebate + sponsors; the film exists with certainty. **Budget B "the ambition" €1.2–1.5M** — adds the second partner, bigger post, archive buy-ups, score recording, delivery war chest; unlocked by streamer/EP/market money. Every financier respects a producer who shows the film exists at A and gets bigger at B. Nobody funds a plan where the film dies without the last, least likely euro.

7 • The financing stack (three lanes, sequenced)

Lane 1 — soft money (the foundation, 50–70%): HAVC production (10 Sept; with co-producer on the prijavnica because čl. 7 scores their last 3 films) › HRT pre-sale (LOI now, call ~Dec–Feb) › IT/HU minority partners bringing their national funds › **Eurimages** (docs: ≤25% of budget, cap

€500k; needs ≥ 2 member-state producers, $\geq 50\%$ financing confirmed per country at filing, deferrals+in-kind count $\leq 15\%$; $>€150k$ is a repayable advance from first-euro receipts at its financing share) › **Croatian rebate 25%+5%** (docs min spend €60k; apply ≥ 8 days before a production block WITH proof of 70% financing; pays after audit + ~90 days › it finances post/delivery, never the shoot) › city/county culture calls (€3–10k tier) › Whickers/Doc Society/Field of Vision (US-FUNDS.md). **Ceiling check:** GBER caps total public aid ~50% of budget, 60% for cross-border co-pros — HAVC legal confirms the math. **Lane 2 — brands (the shoot-saver):** Mares (warm via Sanda) · Molchanovs (Lastovo teaches their curriculum) · Garmin (owns no freediving story) · Croatian pride tier · US road-trip barter (RV, GoPro). Keep $< 10\text{--}15\%$ of budget, contracted as content/credits, never touching the cut, disclosed consistently. **Lane 3 — the market (the endgame):** sales agent MG/pre-sales from rough cut · streamer acquisition post-premiere (\$300k–1.5M realistic band) · Croatian theatrical + adventure tours + windowed digital as the no-streamer floor. **Not in the stack:** equity and gap debt. Every euro of them sits above you in the waterfall forever; at doc revenue levels they usually ARE the entire net. Your no-cheap-equity instinct is arithmetic, not stubbornness.

Paper your own money — now, per the DPA waterfall rules: as financier of your own film you must treat yourself with the same formality as a stranger. The Documentary Producers Alliance framework: deferred fees (up to their budgeted amounts) recoup **first** from first income, or convert to sweat equity recouping alongside investors at the same premium; every participant at a tier is paid pro rata pari passu; and **soft money you raised counts toward your share of net profits**. Also note the DPA credit tiers your future EPs will expect: financing $\geq 50\%$ of budget = Presentation credit + up to 4 EP credits; $\geq 20\%$ = "In Association with" + up to 2; $\geq 10\%$ = one EP credit — while working credits (Producer/Co-/Associate) may never be bought or sold. Document your ~€35k+ contribution and your deferred fees this way today, so no later investor can accidentally (or deliberately) subordinate you.

8 • Cash flow — the trough

Everything pays late: HAVC in milestone tranches, rebate after audit, Eurimages in instalments (then recoups), broadcasters on delivery, the streamer years from now. A "fully financed" €1.2M film still spends quarters at **-€100–200k** cumulative. Your defenses: (1) the **cumulative cash-flow worksheet** — build it with the financing plan, update monthly, show financiers (it reads as competence); (2) sequence shoots behind confirmed tranches; (3) bridge instruments — Croatian bank discounting against a signed HAVC contract or the rebate's provisional certificate; (4) deferring your own fees (the classic float — contractually, with a defined repayment trigger); (5) your €10–25k = the personal float for exactly Lastovo+USA, already gated. **Never float payroll taxes.**

9 • Waterfall & CAMA — where revenue actually goes

Order: CAM fee › agent commission (doc norm 20–25%; fight for 15–20%; $>30\%$ red flag) › agent's **capped** expenses › debt › Eurimages recoupment corridor › deferrals › net split among co-producers. Worked example: €500k of sales › ~€170k to the majority producer — normal, plan on it. **CAMA** (Freeway or Fintage; Eurimages has a Freeway framework): all buyers pay one neutral account, disbursed per the contract — the agent never touches your money. Written into the co-production agreement from day one; a sales agent who refuses a CAMA is telling you who they are.

PART IV — THE MACHINERY (*full detail in RESEARCH-LEGAL-DELIVERY.md*)

10 • Company & chain of title

The film must be owned by the d.o.o., not by you-the-person. Every right flows to it in writing: **your own director agreement with your own company** (yes, really — copyright vests in authors; buyers look for this hole first), crew IP assignments (re-paper Krk/Sicily onto the company once registered), releases, locations, music, archive, financing agreements. **The binder discipline:** every agreement filed the day it's signed, one-line index, producible in 24 hours. Chain of title is checked at four gates — E&O, treaty certification, and the sale twice. What breaks it: the unsigned release, the freelancer who never signed, festival-only music licenses, verbal co-pro promises, contracts signed personally.

11 • Releases & the 2023 chapter (the legal heart of this film)

- **Everyone recognizable** signs an appearance release **on the day of filming**. Camp students at Lastovo sign the one-pager between dives (RELEASES-DRAFT.md Annex C).
- **The four** sign life-story-style agreements: cooperation + personal archive licensing + exclusivity + **covenant not to sue** — the clause E&O underwriters love most. Control: **never cut approval**; the defensible middle we designed honors the working-paper promise as a *viewing + factual-correction right limited to the defined 2023 Chapter* — streamer-compatible and morally straight.
- **The blackout:** specific consent to that footage (Petar + safety divers + medics). Privacy ≠ defamation — true medical facts can still violate privacy. His post-blackout interview is the context that makes use of it honest.
- **The 2023 chapter protocol:** (1) the **annotation file** — every factual assertion in the cut footnoted to a document, on-record interview, or official finding; language discipline: adjudicated fact ("sanctioned under a code of ethics; tests negative") vs allegation; (2) **right of reply** — before lock, written summaries of the specific claims to the other side (organiser, CMAS), their response or "declined" in the film, correspondence archived; (3) **legal read of the fine cut before lock** — juxtaposition can defame even when every line is true; (4) E&O bound off the back of 1–3. Done early this LOWERS the premium; done late it forces post-lock recuts, the most expensive edits in film.

12 • Insurance & the contracts shelf

Two policies: production package per shoot (gear, liability, media; dive/marine riders for us) and E&O (\$1M/\$3M limits, 3-year term, €10–20k our profile, start the application at rough cut). **The shelf, each with its non-negotiable:** director agreement (assignment + defined cuts, financeable replacement clause) · crew deal memos (economic-rights assignment + consent to modifications — drafted for Croatian law, not US "work-for-hire" boilerplate; no-injunction clause) · composer package

deal (company owns composition + master, or watertight all-media perpetual license; composer keeps PRO writer's share — free to you; **stems contractually delivered**) · editor agreement (defined cuts + overages + materials custody + post-lock services) · co-production agreement (shares, spend geography, waterfall, delegate producer, credits, CAMA, final cut protected) · sales agency agreement (commission, **hard expense cap €20–40k**, 7–10yr term with performance reversion, prize money excluded, no cross-collateralization, CAMA) · license agreements (holdbacks must fit the festival/HRT plan; 10% signature / 90% **on delivery**).

13 · Delivery — the thing that kills films (so it won't kill ours)

The buyer's delivery schedule = picture masters (texted AND **textless** — our lower-thirds/depth-counters/subtitles make the textless build real work: do it during the online) · 5.1 + stereo + **filled M&E** (vérité's trap: dialogue and ambient share the mic; the M&E must be *built during the mix* or it costs thousands later) · stems · timecoded bilingual dialogue/spotting list · CC/SDH · complete chain of title · E&O cert · cue sheet · credits/billing with **HAVC/Eurimages logo obligations** · 50–200 stills (**shot during production — Etna cannot be re-staged**) · layered key art · QC pass (fails on loudness, sync, archival artifacts, M&E holes; failed QC = 4–8 lost weeks). Realistic cost **€25–60k, 2–4 months**. Our prevention, standing orders: streamer spec in front of the post supervisor before any post contract; M&E/textless/stems/spotting in the sound-house and online deal memos; 5% of post held as delivery contingency; stills assigned on every remaining shoot starting Lastovo.

PART V — THE MARKET

14 · Post-production as strategy (not just craft)

Paper edit from the interview architecture (the five returning questions ARE the string-out structure — the app's interview library is built for this) › assembly (editor hired Nov–Dec; cut AWAY from your attachment: you shot it, the editor owes the footage nothing) › rough cut (spring 2027) › **feedback screenings**: small, structured, strangers included, written questions before discussion; run 2–3 of them — films that skip this premiere their blind spots › fine cut › edit lab window (IDFAcademy / Ex Oriente / Sundance Edit & Story Lab — labs are also where ARTE and agents fall in love) › **legal read** › lock › finishing. The bigger swings (physiological score, real-time dive, four-voices monologue) get tested at rough cut and killed without mercy if they don't play — the bible's own rule.

15 · Festival › sale mechanics

Premiere status is currency: world > international > European; a top-tier world premiere is bought once and never refunded — nothing public before the premiere festival clears it. The exact rules (verified): Sundance competition = world premiere, ANY prior public exhibition kills it; TIFF = North American premiere minimum, "public" = advertised/ticketed; **IDFA allows up to two prior festival screenings and even a home-country theatrical/TV release** — the one flexibility in

the system, useful if the Croatian release ever needs to move early. Private, unadvertised feedback screenings never count. Budget a **festival publicist (\$5–15k per major festival)** for the premiere — reviews and trade coverage at the premiere are literally sales collateral. **The sequence:** IDFA Forum (Nov 2026, film unfinished — financing room, not premiere) › agent courted from sizzle, formally attached at rough cut (they now board early and may bring money/editorial notes — normal, cap their expenses) › Cannes Docs market screenings (May 2027; market ≠ premiere, status safe) › **world premiere Telluride/TIFF Sept 2027** (Plan B: Tribeca June; Plan C: CPH:DOX/IDFA 2027 as premiere instead of European slot) › buyers watch at the festival and on screeners; deals close **months after** — *All That Breathes* won Sundance and sold to HBO four months later; at Sundance 2026 not a single doc deal closed during the festival and the industry line is deals now "take up to a year" — so no in-festival bidding panic, the agent works the room and the finance plan never depends on a fast sale › then the genre circuit with no status cost: Banff (› world tour), Kendal, ocean tours, FICTS — the *Alpinist* long-tail engine › Croatian theatrical event release (four national heroes = real domestic box office) › windowed digital if no global buy. **Buyers, ranked for us:** Netflix (bought freediving twice; *Deepest Breath* ~8M views/2 wks; acquisitions via Del Deo, sports via Spitzer — access+stakes+characters is their stated triad) · Nat Geo (Free Solo/Rescue heritage) · HBO/Max · ARTE La Lucarne / ZDF / YLE via the co-producer · Red Bull Studios as co-financier (price = control). **Pitch as adventure-thriller-with-heart in the Free Solo lane — never "issue doc," never "another Deepest Breath"** (ours: alive, present-tense, ensemble, vindication).

16 • The EP move

The Deepest Breath sold to Netflix before its premiere because of the package (Battsek/A24). Our equivalent: after the premiere strategy is set and the sizzle is strong, ask the sales agent to matchmake **one respected adventure-doc EP** (the Chin/Vasarhelyi, Noah Media, Ventureland tier). Cost: a fee and a credit. Return: the streamer's phone answers. Timing: rough cut, from strength — never now, at maximum weakness.

PART VI — EXECUTION

17 • The traps, each with its guard (first-timer killers › Deep Dive answers)

1. **Overshooting without structure** › the five returning questions are the structure; log/select after every block in the app; paper edit before the editor arrives.
2. **Missing paper** › releases at Lastovo; binder discipline; re-paper Krk/Sicily; lawyer this month.
3. **Post & delivery unbudgeted** › the 30%-after-the-shoot rule; €25–60k delivery line; 5% delivery contingency — in Budget A, not just B.
4. **No E&O until the buyer asks** › application at rough cut; annotation file grows from Lastovo onward, not retro-fitted.
5. **Blown premiere status** › nothing from the film public pre-premiere; sizzle stays in private links; BTS social ≠ film footage.

6. **No sales strategy until the film is done** › agent conversations start at IDFA 2026 with the sizzle.
7. **Money runs out in post** › cash-flow worksheet monthly; rebate banked for post; edit begins only with the edit financed.
8. **The uncapped sales agent / cross-collateralization / no CAMA** › §12 checklist; walk away is a position.
9. **Solo-producer burnout** › the delegation ladder (§2) is calendared like a deadline: PM days by August, co-producer by September, editor by November.
10. **The sensitive chapter handled late** › right-of-reply and legal read are IN the schedule (pre-lock), owned, budgeted.

18 • Operating cadence (how you run this from tomorrow)

- **The producer hour, daily at fixed time:** paper, money, email — before creative work eats the day.
- **Weekly:** cash position vs worksheet · pipeline (every open application/conversation, one line each) · binder check (what got signed this week?).
- **Per shoot block:** pre-block (insurance, permits, releases printed, stills assigned, two-copies backup rule) · post-block (footage logged, releases filed, costs reported, one-page "what the film gained" note).
- **Monthly:** cost report (budget vs actual vs estimate-to-complete) — the habit that makes HAVC/Eurimages audits trivial and financiers calm.
- **The app is the production office:** schedule, contacts, releases tracker, interview library, sponsor pipeline, archive log. What isn't in the system doesn't exist.

19 • This week (14–25 July) — the sprint, restated once more

1. **Sizzle** (team cuts, you direct) › 2. **d.o.o. "OneMasterTake" + Očevidnik filed** › 3. **IDFA Forum entry by the 24th** (draft ready, fill [TOMO] fields) › 4. **Releases to lawyer › print for Lastovo** › 5. **Email Vanja/Restart + ISHOF** › 6. **Lastovo shoot bible + stills plan + hydrophone/biolum test kit** › 7. Lastovo, 20th: shoot begins — and the producer hour survives the boat.

The film is the four of them holding each other in the dark. The production is you holding the film — with paper, money, and a calendar. Both are load-bearing. Idemo.